

» MATCH OF THE
FORTNIGHT

A CATALAN CATASTROPHE

Girona handed Barcelona a shock defeat in La Liga, adding credence to its fairytale pursuit of the league crown.

BARCELONA

2

Robert
Lewandowski 19'
Ilkay
Gundogan 90'+2'

GIRONA

4

Artem Dovbyk 12'
Miguel
Gutierrez 40'
Valery
Fernandez 80'
Cristhian
Stuani 90'+5'

Usually, the top five leagues in Europe, over the years, have been accustomed to crowning some familiar names as champions at the end of the season. But now and then, there comes a team which breaks the norm. In the Premier League, Leicester City had a fairytale season in the 2015-16 season. Last season, Napoli revived the magic of the Diego Maradona era by clinching the Scudetto. This season, La Liga is seeing a similar story in Girona, which currently sits among the top three in the table with 44 points, after 17 matches.

To add some context to the gravity of this achievement, the club made their first division (La Liga) debut only in the previous decade (2017-18 season) and has since competed in only three seasons before this year, finishing never higher than 10th.

Magical seasons produce magical results, especially when the weaker teams beat the Goliaths of the league. That, complemented by a bit of luck, cooks up a perfect underdog story for the ages.

And Girona looks on course to writing its own after a fantastic 4-2 win against defending champion Barcelona.

The match had a fast start, with Artem Dovbyk opening the scoring for the visitors in the 12th minute. But the Catalans replied swiftly with an equaliser by Robert Lewandowski seven minutes later.

Then started the Barca dominance. At times, the Girona defence was all over the place but somehow hung on amidst a barrage of attacks from the home team.

With half-time on the horizon, Miguel Gutierrez scored against the run of play to provide a 2-1 lead to Girona. After a one-two with Ivan Martin, Gutierrez dropped a shoulder to wrongfoot Jules Kounde, cut in and curled the ball past Barca keeper Inaki Pena Sotorres.

Barca started the second half strongly and even brought on Lamine Yamal and Ferran Torres to sharpen its attack. However, Xavi's men lacked the finishing touch and were punished again in the 80th minute, this time by Valery Fernandez, who found the net just two minutes after coming on.

While it did pull a goal back in the second minute of additional time via Ilkay Gundogan, any comeback hopes were squashed by Cristhian Stuani, who made it 4-2 in the 95th minute to complete an extraordinary upset.



Giant killer: Miguel Gutierrez (No. 3) scores the second goal for Girona, which looks set to achieve its best ever finish in La Liga. REUTERS
Top: Ilkay Gundogan looks devastated after Barca's defeat. GETTY IMAGES

